

The Purpose of the Good, and How Sacrifice Reveals It

A topical Bible study on Religion, Worship, Sacrifice, and the Obedience of Faith. All Scripture quotations are from the NET Bible.

The Good has a source, not just a definition. Scripture treats goodness as inseparable from God's own character rather than an abstract standard. Jesus makes this explicit when he redirects a man's compliment back to its source: *"No one is good except God alone"* (Mark 10:18). Because *"the Good"* is God's nature, its *"purpose"* is God's purpose: to unite people to Himself and remake them in His likeness. That purpose stays theoretical, however, until something forces it into the open.

Sacrifice is what makes an inward disposition verifiable. Belief and devotion are invisible, even to the person who holds them, until they cost something. Genesis 22 sets the template: God doesn't ask Abraham for sincerity, but for *"your son, your only son, whom you love"* (Genesis 22:2). Hebrews reads this as the definition of faith itself; conviction that never gets paid for isn't yet faith (Hebrews 11:17-19). This is why sacrifice *illuminates* the Good rather than just referring to it. Sacrifice converts a claim into an event.

Partial sacrifice is the recurring counterfeit. Scripture is far more concerned with incomplete sacrifice than with open refusal. Saul keeps the best of the plunder and still calls it worship; Samuel's response is the Old Testament's sharpest statement on the whole problem: *"obedience is better than sacrifice; paying attention is better than the fat of rams"* (1 Samuel 15:22). Malachi levels the identical charge at priests offering blind, lame, and stolen animals (Malachi 1:8, 13-14); the ritual continues, but the best part has been quietly withheld. Jesus closes this loophole for discipleship entirely: no half-version qualifies (Luke 14:26-33), and James names the resulting condition plainly; religion running alongside an un-surrendered life is *"futile"* (James 1:26-27). This is the mechanism behind ordinary spiritual mediocrity: not refusal, but negotiated, partial compliance still called devotion.

Four terms, four depths of one act. Religion is the outward form; the observance and community shape devotion takes (James 1:26-27). Worship is the inward disposition; Jesus relocates it from geography to sincerity: *"the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth"* (John 4:23-24). Sacrifice is the cost that proves the disposition real; Augustine's definition captures this precisely: *"a true sacrifice is every work which is done that we may be united to God in holy fellowship"* (City of God X.6). And the *obedience of faith* (Romans 1:5) is what the whole pattern is called once it becomes a settled way of life rather than a single act; the explicit goal of Paul's apostleship, and the frame later Restoration-movement writers insisted on: faith that hasn't reached obedience hasn't fully arrived yet.

Even virtue's smallest disciplines follow this same shape. Temperance requires surrendering a real, immediate good, the pleasure of excess, for a good not yet present. It is sacrifice in miniature: the same structural choice as Abraham's, repeated daily, with no altar to mark the moment of decision.

The pattern is only possible because it was completed first by God who is Good. Christ's own life is described as this same total, fully obedient, sacrifice carried all the way through (Hebrews 10:5-10). This

is why Paul grounds the *"living sacrifice"* of Romans 12:1 in *"the mercies of God"*; a response to a finished work, not an independent effort to earn one. The believer's obedient sacrifice doesn't create the union with God; it enacts a union that He already made possible.

1. Framing the Question

The question *"what is the purpose of the Good?"* is really a question about God. In Scripture, God is not merely good among other things, good is what He is. Jesus makes this identification directly when a man calls him "good teacher":

"Good Teacher, what must I do to inherit eternal life?" Jesus said to him, "Why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone." (Mark 10:17–18)

Jesus is not denying his own goodness. He is pointing the man to the source: goodness is not a free-floating quality people can possess independently. It is an attribute of God, and anything called good is good because it participates in Him. This means the *"purpose of the Good"* is not an abstract ethical puzzle. It is the purpose of God being known, loved, and reflected in a creature who is not naturally like Him. **The Good has a purpose because God has a purpose; to be united with the people He made, and to remake them in His likeness (Genesis 1:26–27; Romans 8:29).**

Sacrifice is the mechanism Scripture uses, from Genesis to Revelation, to move a person from merely admiring the Good in the abstract to actually being conformed to it. **This is why sacrifice and worship sit so close together in the biblical vocabulary, and why obedience, not sentiment, is the proof that worship has happened.**

2. Sacrifice as the Thing That Makes the Good Concrete

Abstract goodness costs a person nothing. A sacrifice is goodness with a price attached, and the price is what makes it real. This is the pattern set at the very start of Abraham's story:

God said, "Take your son - your only son, whom you love, Isaac - and go to the land of Moriah! Offer him up there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains which I will indicate to you." (Genesis 22:2)

God does not ask Abraham to *feel* devoted. He asks him to hand over the one thing Abraham cannot part with and keep his own plans intact. The text spells out exactly what is being asked: not a possession, not a habit, but *"your son... your only son... whom you love."* The sacrifice only means something because it costs Abraham the thing he loves most.

The writer of Hebrews reads this event as the interpretive key to what faith is:

By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac. He had received the promises, yet he was ready to offer up his only son... and he reasoned that God could even raise him from the dead, and in a sense he received him back from there. (Hebrews 11:17, 19)

Abraham's faith was not a private conviction that stayed inside his head. It became visible, became actual, only in the moment he raised the knife. That is the whole argument of Hebrews 11: faith is commended not because people believed correctly, but because their belief cost them something and they paid it. Abel's offering (Hebrews 11:4), Noah's ark (11:7), Moses' choice to be "*ill-treated with the people of God*" rather than "*enjoy sin's fleeting pleasure*" (11:25); every example is a person converting invisible conviction into a visible, costly act. That conversion is what sacrifice is.

This is why sacrifice illuminates the Good instead of merely referring to it. The Good, as an idea, is easy to affirm. The Good, as a sacrifice, forces a decision: will you give this up? The answer to that question, not the sincerity of the sentiment beforehand, is what Scripture treats as real.

3. The Structure of Sacrifice

3.1 You must be willing to be separated from a particular good in order to give it to God.

This is simply what a burnt offering *is*. The Hebrew term is *olah*; that which "goes up," entirely consumed, kept back for nothing. Leviticus prescribes an unblemished animal precisely because the value of the gift is what makes it a gift. Paul transfers this logic onto the whole person:

Therefore, I exhort you, brothers and sisters, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a sacrifice, alive, holy, and pleasing to God, which is your reasonable service. (Romans 12:1)

The NET Bible's own study note on this verse makes a dry but pointed observation: "*the problem with living sacrifices is that they keep crawling off the altar.*" A dead sacrifice cannot renegotiate. A living one can and constantly wants to. This is the whole tension herein described; the "good" you're asked to separate from doesn't stay separated on its own. You must keep laying it back down.

3.2 Influences subvert the remaining part of the sacrifice that inhibits giving to the end.

Scripture is blunt that sacrifices are frequently *partial* (offered, but not offered *whole*) and that this partiality is treated as an insult rather than an approximation of obedience:

"There will be harsh condemnation for the hypocrite who has a valuable male animal in his flock but vows and sacrifices something inferior to the Lord. For I am a great king," says the Lord who rules over all. (Malachi 1:14)

You are offering improper sacrifices on my altar, yet you ask, "How have we offended you?" By treating the table of the Lord as if it is of no importance!... you offer blind animals as a sacrifice, is that not wrong? And when you offer the lame and sick, is that not wrong as well? (Malachi 1:7-8)

Notice what Malachi's audience is doing: they are still sacrificing. They have not stopped. They have simply kept back the best part and offered the leftover. That is exactly the pattern this article calls "*subverting the remaining part of the sacrifice*"; not outright refusal, but a negotiated, partial compliance that still gets called worship. Saul does the same thing on a larger scale in 1 Samuel 15, keeping the best of the plunder and calling it a sacrifice (1 Samuel 15:15, 21); Samuel's answer is the most direct statement in the Old Testament of the whole problem:

Does the Lord take pleasure in burnt offerings and sacrifices as much as he does in obedience? Certainly, obedience is better than sacrifice; paying attention is better than the fat of rams. For rebellion is like the sin of divination, and presumption is like the evil of idolatry. (1 Samuel 15:22–23)

Saul's sacrifice is not fake, the animals are real, the altar is real, the ritual is real. What is fake is the *completeness* of it. He performed sacrifice as a substitute for the specific obedience God asked for. This is precisely the mechanism: religious activity used to disguise an unfinished surrender.

3.3 You must be willing to give total commitment to God, the 'goodness of sacrifice.'

Jesus states the total-commitment requirement without any softening:

"If anyone comes to me and does not hate his own father and mother, and wife and children, and brothers and sisters, and even his own life, he cannot be my disciple. Whoever does not carry his own cross and follow me cannot be my disciple." (Luke 14:26–27)

"In the same way therefore not one of you can be my disciple if he does not renounce all his own possessions." (Luke 14:33)

Jesus frames this with the tower-builder and the king weighing battle odds (Luke 14:28–32); the point being that half-committed discipleship is not a smaller version of the real thing; it is a *failure to finish what was started*, which is worse than never starting, because the half-built tower stands as public evidence of insincerity. Total commitment is not one possible level of devotion among others. It is the only kind Jesus recognizes as discipleship at all.

3.4 You are tempted to hold it back... you often can't give the 'die to yourself to the end' commitment.

Paul names the mechanism for why this is hard, and locates it correctly; not as a single bad choice but as an ongoing internal war:

Do you not know that if you present yourselves as obedient slaves, you are slaves of the one you obey, either of sin resulting in death, or obedience resulting in righteousness? (Romans 6:16)

Every person is already a slave to something. "Holding back" a sacrifice is not neutral; it is choosing to keep serving the other master a little longer. This is why the temptation feels so persistent; it isn't resisting one demand; it's the ongoing pull of an entire competing allegiance (compare Matthew 6:24).

3.5 Influences convince people that they cannot be separated from a particular good and thus fall short of the 'obedience of faith.'

This connects directly to Romans 1:5, where Paul describes the entire purpose of his apostleship:

Through him we have received grace and our apostleship to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles on behalf of his name. (Romans 1:5)

The phrase "*obedience of faith*" (Greek *hypakoē pisteōs*) is intentionally compact. Early interpreters and later Restoration-era writers alike have read it two ways that are not actually in conflict: (a) obedience *that consists of* faith; believing itself is an act of submission to God's terms rather than one's own, and (b) the obedience *that faith produces*; real faith cannot stay inert. Either reading rules out the idea that a person can hold something back from God while still calling their faith genuine. The "influences" we encounter (i.e. demonic, spiritual, cultural, psychological) do their work exactly at this seam; they convince a person that faith is compatible with keeping a particular good in reserve. Scripture's answer, consistently, is that this is a category error. Faith that does not reach obedience has simply not arrived yet.

3.6 This may be the cause of mediocrity in every human being.

This is close to the diagnosis James gives for a certain kind of empty religiosity:

If someone thinks he is religious yet does not bridle his tongue, and so deceives his heart, his religion is futile. Pure and undefiled religion before God the Father is this: to care for orphans and widows in their misfortune and to keep oneself unstained by the world. (James 1:26–27)

James's word for "religion" (*threskeia*) refers to the outward system of observance; the rituals, the identity markers, the things a person *does* to count as religious. His point is that this outward system can run in parallel with an un-surrendered inner life indefinitely, producing exactly the "mediocrity" described herein; a person who is sincerely religious and simultaneously withholding. Mediocrity, on this reading, is not laziness. It is the stable, sustainable state of partial sacrifice; Saul's kept livestock, Malachi's blemished lambs, the seed choked by "*the worries of this life, the deceitfulness of wealth*" (Matthew 13:22). It looks like devotion because activity is present. What is missing is completion.

3.7 Virtue and Temperance as the Same Structure in Miniature

Consider the example of *temperance* as a virtue. This scales the whole argument down to a single daily choice. Paul uses an athletic metaphor for this same discipline:

Everyone who competes in the games exercises self-control in everything. They do it to receive a perishable wreath, but we an imperishable one. (1 Corinthians 9:25)

Temperance requires giving up a real, immediate good (the pleasure of excess) for the sake of a good that is not immediately present (discipline, health, virtue, communion with God). This is sacrifice in miniature; the same structural choice as Abraham's, scaled to an ordinary decision. If the structure of sacrifice really is foundational to human moral life, then temperance is not a separate virtue alongside sacrifice; it is sacrifice practiced at the smallest possible scale, which is exactly why it is one of the hardest disciplines to sustain. The *"lesser good of what I get out of it,"* must be surrendered constantly, in small transactions, with no dramatic moment like Moriah to mark the decision. This is arguably *harder* than Abraham's test, not easier; there is no altar, no fixed point of completion, just the same choice repeated.

4. Religion, Worship, Sacrifice, and the Obedience of Faith: How the Terms Relate

Scripture uses these four terms with real precision, even though English translations often blur them together. It helps to see them as four layers of the same act, moving from outward frame to inward reality.

Religion (*threskeia*) is the outward system; the observances, the community, the identifiable practice. James 1:26–27 uses this word specifically and immediately defines "pure" religion not by its rituals, but by what it produces; care for the vulnerable and an unstained life. Religion is the *shape* worship takes in a community; it is not, by itself, proof that anything real has happened inside the worshiper.

Worship is the posture of the heart directed toward God; recognition of who He is and submission to it. Jesus relocates worship away from geography and ritual correctness and onto sincerity of spirit:

"But a time is coming, and now is here, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, for the Father seeks such people to be his worshipers. God is spirit, and the people who worship him must worship in spirit and truth." (John 4:23–24)

This is a decisive move. Worship is not primarily a place or a form (Jerusalem or Gerizim) but a disposition. But (and this is the crucial point) a disposition by itself is invisible and unverifiable, including to the worshiper. This is exactly why worship needs sacrifice.

Sacrifice (*thusia*) is worship's currency; the concrete cost by which an invisible disposition becomes an actual, verifiable event. Augustine's *City of God* states this relationship as precisely as any writer ever has:

"A true sacrifice is every work which is done that we may be united to God in holy fellowship, and which has a reference to that supreme good and end in which alone we can be truly blessed." (City of God, Book X, Chapter 6)

Augustine draws this definition directly out of Romans 12:1 and Hosea 6:6, and he uses it to explain why the Old Testament's outward sacrifices were never the point in themselves; they were always symbols pointing to the inward, whole life sacrifice they were meant to produce. In his words, mercy shown to another person *"if it is not shown for God's sake, is not a sacrifice"*; meaning the same external act can be sacrifice or can be nothing at all, depending entirely on whether it is offered to God. This is the same

logic Samuel applies to Saul and Malachi applies to the priests: the ritual form does not guarantee the substance.

The Obedience of Faith (*hypakoē pisteōs*, Romans 1:5) is the completed result; the point at which worship has been proven real because it has been enacted as sacrifice, consistently, to the point of costing something. This is why Paul can say that the entire purpose of the gospel going out to the nations is to "bring about the obedience of faith" (Romans 1:5); not merely correct belief, and not merely religious observance, but a life that has actually reorganized itself around what it claims to believe.

Putting the four together: Religion supplies the *form*. Worship supplies the *disposition*. Sacrifice supplies the *proof*; the moment the disposition costs something and the person pays it. The *obedience of faith* is what you call the whole thing once it has become a settled pattern of life rather than an isolated act. A person can have religion without worship (empty ritual, Isaiah 29:13), worship without sacrifice (sincere feeling that never costs anything, Ezekiel 33:31–32), and even sacrifice without full obedience (Saul's partial compliance dressed up as devotion, 1 Samuel 15). Only when all four align (form, disposition, cost, and settled pattern) does Scripture call it what Paul calls it; *the obedience of faith*.

5. Why Christ's Own Sacrifice Is the Template, Not Just the Payment

It would be easy to read all of this as a description of what is required *of us* and miss that the pattern is first fulfilled *in Christ*, which is what makes it possible for anyone else. The writer of Hebrews quotes Psalm 40 and puts these words in Christ's mouth at his incarnation:

"Sacrifice and offering you did not desire, but a body you prepared for me... Then I said, 'Here I am: I have come — it is written of me in the scroll of the book — to do your will, O God.'" ... By his will we have been made holy through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.
(Hebrews 10:5, 7, 10)

Christ's whole life is described here as one continuous act of the same total, un-held-back sacrifice Abraham modeled and Saul failed to give; except carried all the way through, with nothing kept back, ending at the cross. This is why Paul can ground the "living sacrifice" of Romans 12:1 in "the mercies of God" rather than in human effort; the pattern of total surrender was completed on our behalf first, and what is asked of the believer is a response to that completed sacrifice, not an independent achievement.

6. Restoration Theology's Reading of "Obedience of Faith"

The Restoration Movement writers of the nineteenth century (reading Scripture with a deliberate return to the practice of the apostolic church rather than later creeds) put particular weight on Romans 1:5 for exactly this reason. Their consistent emphasis was that the New Testament never presents faith and obedience as two separate stages, one internal and one optional. Faith that does not terminate in an actual, external, obeyed act (repentance confessed, baptism submitted to, a life reordered) was treated in this tradition as not yet the faith the New Testament describes at all; consistent with the same logic found in James: "faith, if it does not have works, is dead being by itself" (James 2:17). This reading does not add a *work* to faith as a supplementary requirement; it insists that biblical faith, rightly understood, was never merely an internal state to begin with. Obedience is not the fruit that grows later from a

separate root called faith; obedience is what faith looks like when it is real, in the same way sacrifice is what worship looks like when it is real.

This is the same structural claim herein made about "*mediocrity*." If obedience and faith are treated as separable, a person can indefinitely defer the costly part while still affirming the sincere part; precisely the failure mode Malachi, Samuel, and James all independently diagnose.

7. Summary: The Purpose of the Good

Putting the whole study together:

- **The Good has a purpose** because it is not an abstraction but the character of God, and God's purpose is union with the people He made.
- **Sacrifice exists to make that union verifiable**; to convert an invisible disposition (worship) into an actual, costly, external event that proves the disposition is real.
- **Every topical element discussed herein names a real biblical mechanism**; the necessity of separation (Genesis 22; Romans 12:1), the subverting of partial sacrifice into a substitute for full obedience (Malachi 1; 1 Samuel 15), the requirement of total and not partial commitment (Luke 14:26–33), the internal war against holding back (Romans 6:16), the false comfort that some goods are exempt from surrender, and the resulting mediocrity that James calls "*futile religion*" (James 1:26).
- **Religion, worship, sacrifice, and the obedience of faith are not four separate things**, but four depths of the same act (form, disposition, cost, and settled pattern) and Scripture treats none of the first three as reliable evidence on their own. Only the fourth, sustained obedience flowing from faith, is what the New Testament calls "*acceptable*" (Romans 12:1) worship.
- **The pattern is only possible because Christ completed it first** (Hebrews 10:5–10), which is why the "*living sacrifice*" Paul calls for in Romans 12:1 is offered "*by the mercies of God*"; a response to a finished work, not an independent bid to earn one.